

The hardest trophy to keep

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Argentina will be confronted with the burden of expectations as it attempts to put together a strong World Cup defence.

Brazil was the last nation to triumph in consecutive editions, in 1958 and 1962, and La Albiceleste have a chance to emulate that feat after 64 years, especially given their canter through the Copa America and South American World Cup qualification.

However, despite recent form, an ageing squad and an injury to talisman Lionel Messi in the lead-up to the tournament cast a pall over the side's title challenge. Head coach Lionel Scaloni's squad includes 17 players from the World Cup-winning side from four years ago, and seven of them are over 30 years old, with Messi (38), Rodrigo De Paul (32), Emiliano Martinez (33) and

Nicolas Otamendi (38) among the most notable names. Having to rotate regular starters might not be the safest bet in the high-stakes cauldron of the World Cup.

But familiarity brings consistency, and Argentina will bank on it to build another campaign. The only major switch forced upon Argentina came with the retirement of Angel Di Maria after the Copa America triumph in June 2024.

Scaloni tested his team's wares across multiple systems during the World Cup qualification cycle, including the 4-4-2, 4-3-3 and 4-2-3-1, with Thiago Almada manning the left flank in most instances.

Julian Alvarez's recent surge at Atletico Madrid yielded 20 goals and nine assists, adding further weight to Argentina's attack, which will still see Messi pull the strings for much of the tournament.



ARGENTINA

FIFA ranking: 3

Appearances: 18

Best finish: Champion
(1978, 1986, 2022)

Matches: 88

Wins: 47

Draws: 17

Losses: 24

Goals For: 152

Goals Against: 101

Highest scorer in the squad
Lionel Messi (**116 goals**)



ALGERIA

FIFA ranking: 29

Appearances: 4

Best finish: Round of 16
(2014)

Matches: 13

Wins: 3

Draws: 3

Losses: 7

Goals For: 13

Goals Against: 19

Highest scorer in the squad
Riyad Mahrez (**38 goals**)

